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Culture (OWC): [Tsonga \(FT06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1895-1909

Coverage Date: 1895-1926

Place Coverage: South Africa

Section Title(S): C. OLD AGE AND DEATH

The death of the woman is accompanied by the same rites as the death of a man. I must mention, however, the custom of *mahloko*, which takes place when a woman dies while still in her prime. Mahloko comes from *nhloko*, head. The explanation of this technical word is this: the parents of the woman say: "Our head (viz. a person belonging to us) has died; let us go to mourn her."

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Let us first see how this mourning takes place *in the Ronga clans*.

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If the two families were very friendly, the parents of the deceased will probably bring with them a little girl, saying: "This is our little green meat (mbuti), our little orange (rather sala, fruit of the nsala tree)." They offer her to the husband to take the place of the deceased wife, and a new contract will be made. The widower will then at once pay a first part of the lobolo, £ 5 for instance, and, in the course of time, he will marry his sister-in-law. But generally the visitors are angry, and the mahloko ceremony is very unpleasant. It may be that the deceased wife had not been entirely paid for. In that case her parents will come at the end of the mourning to "claim the herd" (ramela ntlhambi).

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But though there may be no difficult lobola question in the way, uneasiness is felt, because the brothers of the deceased cannot help thinking that their sister has been killed by witchcraft. It was not yet time for her to die; so she must have been bewitched by the husband's family, probably by her co-wives, who were jealous of her. When the Great Mourning took place, they hardly came to the mortuary village. One or two went to see their "head," and mourned her in their own kraal. To day, the day of mahloko, they assemble, and throw bones in order to know who will have to speak, who will receive the mahloko money, whether the money has been bewitched? The whole company starts for the mortuary village, driving a goat before them. They sit down outside in the bush with dark looks; there is no longer any hut to receive them... They have been noticed by the 215 inhabitants of the kraal. One of them, the saluter (mulosi), goes to meet them and offers them a shilling. They keep silence. He tells them the news of the village. They do not answer. He leaves them and comes a second time with a fresh present. Then they consent to tell the news of their home, but they do not enter the village. The same man returns to them a third time with £ 1; they refuse to accept it. He adds 10/. (£ 1.10 is considered the normal sum to be paid as a kind of fine by the widower to the parents of the deceased.) They refuse again: this is an insult! Happily the *ntukulu* is there; he will act as mediator between the two families. The visitors summoned him on their arrival and he has been sitting with them the whole time; is he not the son of their sister? But before he went to them, his father has given him his instructions: "Tell them that I have not eaten your mother." The *ntukulu*, as we shall see, is very free with his maternal uncles. He has the right of teasing them, even insulting them. Seeing that they do not accept the money, he stands and gives vent to his grief, throws sand at them, tries to drive them away, weeps. "No! Father has not killed mother! He is not a wizard! She died a natural death!" They see his tears, and then consent to enter the village.

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